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Peer Tutoring and Reading Habits of First-Year Students: Evidence from Three Universities

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Note: all names, institutions and data in this paper are fictional.

Abstract
This paper asks whether a weekly peer-tutoring program changes how much first-year students read outside class. We followed 412 students at three universities for one semester and compared tutored students with a matched comparison group. Peer tutoring raised weekly reading time by about 2.1 hours. The effect was larger for students who lived far from campus.

Keywords: peer tutoring, reading habits, first-year students

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1. Introduction

Many first-year students read little beyond assigned slides. Universities often respond with extra lectures, but these add to an already full timetable. Peer tutoring is cheaper and lets older students share how they plan their reading. Earlier work has mostly looked at grades rather than reading time.

2. Research question

Our main question is whether joining a weekly peer-tutoring group increases the number of hours first-year students spend reading course materials.

3. Methods

We used a quasi-experimental design with propensity score matching and a difference-in-differences model on reading diaries collected every week. The sample covers 412 first-year students from three public universities in the 2024 autumn semester; 206 joined tutoring groups and 206 did not. Students recorded their reading time in a short online diary each Sunday.

4. Results

Before the program, both groups read about 3.4 hours per week. After twelve weeks, tutored students read 5.6 hours per week while the comparison group read 3.5 hours. Peer tutoring raised weekly reading time by about 2.1 hours. The estimate stays between 1.8 and 2.4 hours across all robustness checks.

The effect was largest among students living more than 10 km from campus, who gained 2.9 hours per week, compared with 1.6 hours for those living on or near campus.

Tran et al. (2021) reported that a similar program raised library visits by 18 percent, which is in line with the direction of our findings.

5. Discussion

Peer tutoring appears to work mainly by helping students plan their week. Tutors shared reading schedules and short summaries of hard chapters.

Challenges reported by the universities

The three universities found it hard to recruit enough tutors in the second half of the semester, and two of them had no quiet rooms for group meetings.

6. Conclusion

A low-cost weekly peer-tutoring program can increase the time first-year students spend reading course materials, especially for commuting students.

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References

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